

Chapter 65: Tiger's Den

"With whom?" Ning Fuyi's voice trembled.

Rong Jin didn't know why she showed such an expression, so he spoke more carefully: "With... Wenzhu. They left early this morning. It's said the matter was urgent, so they didn't have time to tell you."

"However, it wasn't just the two of them. Several other South Courtyard disciples went along, and with everyone watching, there shouldn't be any danger." Rong Jin saw Ning Fuyi's face growing increasingly pale and quickly tried to comfort her.

Ning Fuyi took a deep breath, cleared her jumbled mind, and asked again: "For what reason, and where did they go?"

"Yesterday news came that a sea monster suddenly appeared in the waters off East Mountain¹, with waves rushing ashore and flooding coastal fishing villages. They went to subdue that sea monster." Rong Jin said quickly.

How could it be such a coincidence? The flower fairy died, and then there was a sea monster causing trouble in East Mountain, with Liu Wenzhu coincidentally going along?

"Senior Brother, Wenzhu's trip isn't simple. I must go to East Mountain to see Wenzhu before I can feel at ease." Ning Fuyi quickly explained Li Chao'an's situation. After hearing it, Rong Jin's face also lost all color.

"Elder Pingyao isn't at the sect. Should we first report to the Divine Venerable?" Rong Jin said urgently.

Ning Fuyi shook her head: "Chu Qingqiu is far away in the Eastern Wasteland². How can we report to her? Besides, it would take her half a day to rush back - there's simply no time."

"Then Elder Yuanming..."

"No, this matter can't be revealed to more people." Ning Fuyi said.

Rong Jin had no choice but to compromise: "If there really is treachery, you alone wouldn't be safe either. I'll go with you. I doubt that Li Chao'an would dare do anything to Wenzhu!"

After speaking, Rong Jin immediately intercepted a disciple in mid-air and entrusted his affairs to her. Ning Fuyi's mind was in chaos, and having one more person like Rong Jin gave her some comfort, so she didn't refuse.

So the two immediately set out, using all their strength to fly on swords toward East Mountain.

Throughout the journey, they didn't speak much. Ning Fuyi's heart remained lodged in her throat. She hadn't experienced the feeling of fear for a hundred years. Even when facing life and death, she remained unfazed, but now she was once again gripped by terror. Her palms were soaked with sweat that wouldn't dry no matter how she wiped.

The image of that figure burning in fierce flames from her previous life kept flashing before her eyes. The more she thought about it, the more even the white clouds beneath her feet seemed to take the shape of flames, making her spine chill.

East Mountain was only a hundred li away from Tiger's Den³ where Liu Wenzhu had died in her previous life. Ning Fuyi's heart had been haunted by an ominous premonition, but she didn't dare think too deeply, fearing that her thoughts might become reality.

She still harbored a glimmer of hope. In her previous life, being trapped in Tiger's Den had happened several years later. How could it come so early? Perhaps she was just too nervous. Maybe when they reached East Mountain, she would find that everything was just her imagination.

Thinking this, Ning Fuyi kicked hard at the divine sword beneath her feet. The sword's hilt immediately sparked several fire sparks and became a streak of light. Rong Jin nearly couldn't keep up and had to stick several swift wind talismans on his sword before barely catching sight of Ning Fuyi's shadow.

Even though they were already traveling at full speed, by the time they reached East Mountain, the sun had already set into the sea. Roaring waves shattered the evening glow, and the fishy smell of the sea was everywhere.

East Mountain belonged to the coastal frontier, neither fully mortal nor immortal realm. Half the inhabitants were fishermen who made their living from fishing, while the other half were beast hunters who specialized in capturing spirit beasts across the four seas and eight wastelands.

When Ning Fuyi and Rong Jin landed in the fishing village, the troublesome sea demon had already been captured and brought ashore. It lay stranded on the beach with a belly like a small mountain, blowing bubbles and wailing mournfully.

From afar, they could see the purple robes of South Courtyard disciples, so they put away their spirit swords and landed directly in front of several fellow disciples who were trying to bind the sea demon, immediately raising clouds of sand and startling them.

"Senior Brother Rong Jin? Young Sect Master?" Several people said in surprise. "How did you get here?"

"Where are Li Chao'an and Liu Wenzhu?" Ning Fuyi asked directly, her voice cold and urgent, causing the others to look at each other in confusion.

Finally, a female disciple spoke with difficulty: "We didn't expect Wenzhu to be afraid of water. After we entered the sea, her breath-holding technique failed and she was choked unconscious by seawater. Fortunately, she's fine, but Chao'an took her to rest."

"Wenzhu is best at water techniques - how could she be afraid of water!" Ning Fuyi's anger surged, her phoenix eyes unable to suppress their murderous aura, frightening several disciples older than her into silence.

"Where did they take her?" She suppressed her fury and asked in a low voice.

"We, we don't know either. It should be at a nearby fisherman's house." Several people answered uncertainly.

Seeing them hemming and hawing, Ning Fuyi's anger grew even stronger. So without caring about anything else, she summoned immortal power to her palm, then flipped her hand downward. Pink light immediately shot toward the ground, then scattered into points of starlight, blowing everyone's clothes about.

All the people, including Rong Jin, were shocked. They remembered Ning Fuyi as only being at the Mortal Realm⁴. How could she have such cultivation now?

Moreover, her immortal power was obviously more stable and profound than others of the same cultivation level, as if she had been practicing for a long time and could use it effortlessly and continuously.

Ning Fuyi ignored how others reacted and forcibly extended her divine consciousness using immortal power. Her cultivation wasn't yet able to handle such a wide range of vision. For a moment, it felt like a heavy sword piercing her skull, causing her vision to darken as her consciousness searched through the mountains like a dragon, desperately seeking Liu Wenzhu's aura.

In just a moment, her consciousness had followed the aura and explored extremely far, when a scene that had appeared countless times in her nightmares suddenly burst into her mind.

Her consciousness swept past forests and reefs in the howling wind before returning to her consciousness sea. Her throat filled with a metallic sweetness, and she suddenly bent over coughing, pale blood flowing from the corner of her mouth.

"Ning Fuyi, you don't want to live anymore!" Seeing this, Rong Jin quickly supported her. The usually good-tempered man scolded sternly, frantically pulling a handkerchief from his sleeve and pressing it into Ning Fuyi's palm. "You should have asked me to do it! How can divine consciousness be used so forcefully? If you accidentally separate your consciousness from your body, even the greatest immortal couldn't save you!"

But Ning Fuyi seemed not to hear his words. She just stared at the wet sand beneath her feet, gasping for breath, letting the blood from the corner of her mouth drip down and seep into the sand.

Originally, everything had come too suddenly, throwing her mind into chaos. But when her worry became reality, all her urgency and anxiety seemed to transform into a dream, becoming surreal.

When she saw that place, her chaotic thoughts suddenly calmed, becoming as still as stagnant water.

She even wanted to laugh a little. Li Chao'an, oh Li Chao'an - she never expected that in this life, she herself had become the variable. If she could return to the day of her rebirth, she would definitely ignore everything else and fight to mutual destruction with her!

She had thought of many possibilities, made many preparations, wanting to change fate and save those who died because of her in her previous life.

But living a second life, she was still like a headless fly unable to find an exit, still unable to protect them.

How unwilling, how truly pathetic.

The woman bent over, her falling hair hiding all her expressions, like a thin blade of grass bent by wind and rain, trembling.

Rong Jin's impression of Ning Fuyi was that although she often burst into tears, it was mostly childish wailing that stopped after crying. He had never seen her like this - biting her teeth and saying nothing. So he was both worried and heartbroken.

"What did you see?" Rong Jin asked softly. He gripped Ning Fuyi's arm and helped her up, facing a face with vacant expression - not the tear-streaked face he had imagined.

Only then did Ning Fuyi seem to come back to herself. She stared at Rong Jin's face for a long time, broke free from his hand, and slowly straightened up, wiping the blood from the corner of her mouth.

"Nothing." Her throat moved as if swallowing something forcefully, then she returned to normal, lightly curving her lips. "I found Wenzhu."

The evening glow quickly faded, and the seaside rocks and distant mountains were covered with a layer of black gauze. The two flew silently on their swords in mid-air, with warm, humid sea wind carrying the fishy smell of the ocean brushing against their cheeks. Below them were green trees, and in the distance was the vast deep sea.

Ning Fuyi intentionally or unintentionally extended her hand, letting the water-like wind sweep past her fingertips.

"We're here." She spoke, and her divine sword obediently returned to the prayer bead. She and Rong Jin landed on a flat area surrounded by unknown plants that couldn't be seen clearly in the night.

The ground beneath their feet was wet and soft, as if one could sink into it with just a step. Rong Jin didn't dare move anymore.

"Wenzhu is here?" Rong Jin turned in a circle. "I can also sense her aura, but I can't find her."

"I know where she is. I can go find her alone, but I need to trouble Senior Brother to return to the sect to find the Divine Venerable and inform her of this matter." Ning Fuyi suddenly said, then instructed, "Most importantly, regarding Li Chao'an's matter - I suspect it's related to the demon race. You must tell the Divine Venerable everything in detail and have her investigate thoroughly."

Rong Jin nodded subconsciously, then frowned: "No, it's not safe for you alone. Tell me where Wenzhu is, I'll go find her, and you should return to the sect first."

"Senior Brother, just do as I say." Ning Fuyi's words seemed to brook no argument, giving Rong Jin no chance to persuade her. "Of all the people I can trust now, besides the Divine Venerable, only Senior Brother remains."

She paused, then said: "Don't worry, I know what I'm doing. I'll bring Wenzhu out completely intact."

The woman's jet-black pupils seemed to contain the night itself. Rong Jin met her gaze for a long time and finally couldn't resist her, so he compromised.

"Fine, I'll go find the Divine Venerable for help. But take care of yourself, and if there's trouble, you must wait for me to return. Don't act rashly!" Rong Jin instructed again.

"Don't worry, I understand." Ning Fuyi smiled and assured him, then watched as Rong Jin's white robes disappeared into the night sky.

Her smile faded as she murmured softly to herself: "Senior Brother, you're still so easy to deceive."

Tiger's Den was called Tiger's Den not because it contained tigers, but after the meaning of "dragon's pool and tiger's den"⁵ - it was originally the ruins of an ancient country called Lian Hai⁶.

This country was famous far and wide as a nation of witchcraft and curses, extremely devoted to sorcery and sacrificial rituals. For this purpose, they specially forged a massive bronze furnace. Every year during the sacrifice, they needed to burn dozens of people alive to pray for Lian Hai's blessings, called "Witch Purification."

Year after year, more and more people were burned alive in the furnace. Over time, this generated extremely heavy resentment. The resentment eventually swallowed Lian Hai, and this ancient country that had existed for only a few decades disappeared into the river of history. Except for native East Mountain people, few knew of its existence.

Ning Fuyi only learned of its existence after accidentally falling into Tiger's Den in her previous life. The resentment in Tiger's Den was so thick it became corporeal, and in her previous life, even multiple elders working together were helpless.

Anyone who entered would be cursed by vengeful spirits within two hours and die with their hearts clawed out. The only way to break the curse was for someone to jump into the bronze furnace with their physical body to appease the vengeful spirits, temporarily dissolving their anger and allowing others to survive.

Simply put, it was trading life for life.

Ning Fuyi slowly searched according to her vague memories. The soil beneath her feet became increasingly soft, finally seeping with moisture. A stone tablet appeared before her, painted with red warning words by East Mountain people to prevent accidental entry.

Not far away was a swamp, with the center showing an eerie red color, bubbling up. Ning Fuyi's sharp eyes spotted a broken lotus wood carving among those blood-red bubbles.

She never expected that after traveling through life, she would step by step walk back to this place.

Ning Fuyi exhaled and without hesitation, leaped straight in.

Footnotes:

¹ **East Mountain (东岳)** - A coastal region in the cultivation world

² **Eastern Wasteland (东荒)** - A remote region where Chu Qingqiu has gone for urgent matters

³ **Tiger's Den (虎穴)** - A dangerous location that will be explained further in the chapter

⁴ **Mortal Realm (凡境)** - One of the cultivation levels in this world's power system

⁵ **Dragon's pool and tiger's den (龙潭虎穴)** - Chinese idiom meaning an extremely dangerous place

⁶ **Lian Hai (殛海)** - The name of the ancient country, literally meaning "Shrouding Sea"